



For the President
9 August 2026

Today's Brief

ISRAEL-GAZA / US: Washington presses Israel to advance the Gaza roadmap as Netanyahu rejects any withdrawal.

IRAN-HORMUZ: An Oman-brokered strait framework nears, but Iran's terms clash with US demands.

CHINA-TAIWAN: Beijing uses an approaching typhoon to assert traffic control over the Taiwan Strait.

DPRK-RUSSIA: A North Korean missile brigade deploys to Russia's Voronezh region.

UKRAINE: Russia strikes Kyiv again as long-range exchanges grind on.

CHINA: Typhoon Dolphin hits Zhejiang, disrupting the Yangtze River Delta.

NOTES: Hezbollah disarmament verification; renewed North Korean missile testing.

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US Presses Israel To Advance Gaza Roadmap as Netanyahu Rejects Withdrawal

We assess that the US-brokered "Board of Peace" roadmap for Gaza entered a contentious phase over the weekend. Washington is pressing Israel to move to a second phase—Israeli force withdrawals tied to the disarmament of Hamas—while Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has publicly ruled out pulling back until Hamas is "completely disarmed." The commander of US Central Command, Admiral Brad Cooper, made a several-hour visit to Israel on 8 August, meeting armed forces chief Lieutenant General Eyal Zamir and senior commanders to assess the multi-front picture and reinforce US pressure to implement the plan.

- Cooper arrived from talks in Bahrain and the United Arab Emirates; press reporting indicates he pressed Israeli counterparts for rapid movement on phase two after the Board of Peace announced Hamas had agreed to disarm.
- In a video statement, Netanyahu said Israel will not withdraw "from our current lines" until Hamas disarms. Israeli security officials assess Hamas signed largely to forestall a renewed ground operation rather than out of genuine intent—a reading that hardens Israel's conditions.
- Israeli strikes across Gaza have continued through the disarmament announcement and the humanitarian toll remains severe, friction that complicates both the roadmap and the US messaging behind it.
- US force protection in-theater remains substantial: dozens of American fighter and refueling aircraft, air-defense batteries, and several thousand troops are deployed in and around Israel, a posture that deters Iran but also ties US credibility to the outcome.

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For Washington, the near-term risk is that the roadmap stalls between a Hamas that has promised to disarm and an Israel that will not move first, leaving US forces exposed and the President's signature initiative in limbo. We expect continued US shuttle pressure this week; a credible verification-and-sequencing mechanism is the decision point that would let both sides move.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, INR, and open sources.

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Iran Nears Hormuz Framework With Oman but Attaches Terms Washington Rejects

We assess that a partial reopening of the Strait of Hormuz is close but not assured. On 8 August, the secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, Mohammad Bagher Zolghadr, publicly attached conditions—lifting the US naval blockade, withdrawing US forces from the Gulf, and a permanent end to the war—even as Tehran said an Oman-brokered framework to restore shipping was in its "final stage" and awaiting parliamentary approval. President Trump said a deal "could be soon" and cast it as Iran's "last chance."

- In parallel, Iran's parliament is advancing a plan to bar US-, Israeli-, and other "hostile"-flagged ships from the strait and to levy transit tolls—demands that collide with the Law of the Sea's right of innocent passage and, if accepted, would set a precedent other chokepoint states could exploit.
- The US position, restated this week, is that any interim routes carry "no approvals, no permissions, and no tolls" and a return to pre-war transit; the gap over an Iranian role in "managing" traffic is the principal obstacle.
- Energy markets remain on edge: Brent crude settled near \$83.5 a barrel at Friday's close and has swung on each headline. Abu Dhabi's national oil company reported attacks on three vessels transiting the strait, underscoring that the waterway is not yet safe even as talks progress.
- Overhead imagery indicates tanker traffic through the strait remains sharply reduced from pre-crisis levels, consistent with Tehran's effective closure since the conflict began.

For Washington, the calculus is whether a face-saving Iranian role in traffic "management" is worth reopening the strait and cooling oil prices, or whether conceding it rewards coercion at a global chokepoint. We judge a limited, toll-free interim arrangement is the most likely outcome if Tehran drops the demand for formal control; failure would keep a war-risk premium in oil and raise the odds of renewed US-Iran incidents.

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Beijing Uses a Typhoon To Assert Traffic Control Over the Taiwan Strait

We assess that China exploited an approaching typhoon to press a jurisdictional claim over the Taiwan Strait. Citing Typhoon Dolphin, Chinese authorities ordered that ships transiting northward through the strait's southern entrance from Thursday night comply with mainland "traffic control" instructions—a framing Taipei's Mainland Affairs Council rejected on 8 August as "utterly ridiculous," reaffirming the strait as international waters over which Beijing has no authority to restrict navigation.

- We judge the move fits a pattern of administrative and legal "lawfare"—using ostensibly routine or safety pretexts to normalize PRC jurisdiction over the strait—rather than a prelude to physical interdiction.
- Taiwan's Coast Guard reported no unusual movements by PRC vessels and no reports of interference with shipping communications, indicating the step was declaratory.
- The episode coincided with Taiwan's annual Han Kuang exercises, in which forces practiced dispersal and hardening—Patriot units repositioning and civil airports being fortified—signaling Taipei's focus on resilience.

For the United States and its freedom-of-navigation posture, the concern is incremental erosion of the strait's international status that Beijing can later cite as precedent. The signpost to watch is whether the PRC repeats such "traffic control" claims absent a weather pretext; that would mark a deliberate escalation of the jurisdictional campaign.

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North Korean Missile Brigade Deploys to Russia, Deepening the Pyongyang-Moscow Axis

We assess that military integration between North Korea and Russia is deepening in a way that adds combat power against Ukraine and hard-won operational experience for Pyongyang. Ukrainian military intelligence, in reporting carried by international wires this week, indicates roughly 90 North Korean personnel are deploying alongside Russia's 112th Missile Brigade in Voronezh Oblast, positioned to operate as many as six launchers and up to 120 KN-23 and KN-24 short-range ballistic missiles; a fresh batch of about 40 missiles has already been transferred.

- If the unit becomes operational, it would give Russia additional short-range ballistic fires against Ukrainian cities and infrastructure while letting North Korean crews gather live-fire data against Western-supplied air defenses.
- The deployment comes as Pyongyang resumed testing—launching a short-range ballistic missile from the Wonsan area on 6 August—and as Kim Yo Jong warned of "additional military options" after Japan test-fired a US-made Tomahawk.
- A sensitive source corroborates that additional missile transfers are being negotiated for delivery in the coming weeks.

For Washington, the axis compounds two problems at once: it strains Ukraine's air defenses while advancing North Korea's missile program and hard-currency flows, and it links the European and Indo-Pacific theaters. We expect the arrangement to expand; the near-term indicator is the first confirmed combat launch by North Korean crews on Russian soil.

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Russia Strikes Kyiv Again as Long-Range Exchanges Grind On

We assess no let-up in the air war. Overnight into 8 August, Russian ballistic missiles and drones again struck the Kyiv region, killing at least three people—including a child—in the Brovary district and wounding others, as the capital came under repeated ballistic alert. Ukraine continued its own deep campaign, reporting strikes on twelve Russian "shadow fleet" vessels in the Black Sea and Sea of Azov between 1 and 8 August.

- On the ground, Russian sources claimed incremental gains west of Orikhiv in Zaporizhia; the claims are unverified, and we judge the front remains one of costly, marginal movement rather than breakthrough.
- Ukraine's asymmetric strikes on Russian tankers, ports, and energy nodes are imposing rising economic and logistical costs, a deliberate offset to Russia's advantage in mass.

We see no viable ceasefire track that advanced within the window; the trajectory is continued mutual long-range strikes and attritional ground combat. For Washington, sustaining Ukrainian air defense—especially interceptors against ballistic threats—remains the pacing issue as Russian and, increasingly, North Korean missile stocks are brought to bear.

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Typhoon Dolphin Slams China's East Coast, Disrupting the Yangtze Delta

Typhoon Dolphin made landfall on 9 August at Yuhuan in Zhejiang province after raking Japan's Okinawa, prompting China's national weather service to issue its top-tier red alert. We assess the storm will impose a significant, if temporary, hit to one of China's most economically dense regions.

- Authorities evacuated roughly 500,000 people, suspended ferry routes and offshore projects, and cancelled more than 1,600 flights, including hundreds at Hangzhou and Shanghai-area airports; forecasters warned of "extraordinary" rainfall of 250-500 mm in parts of central and eastern Zhejiang.
- The same system was the pretext Beijing used to assert "traffic control" over the Taiwan Strait, briefly entangling a natural-disaster response with a sovereignty claim.

For the United States, the near-term significance is economic and logistical—disruption to Yangtze River Delta manufacturing, ports, and shipping that can ripple through global supply chains—rather than military. We expect ports and air hubs to reopen within days barring severe inland flooding.

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Notes

- **Lebanon-Israel:** Beirut and Israel agreed on a shortlist of countries that could contribute troops to verify Hezbollah's disarmament under the US-brokered framework, with Washington to select from the list (7 August). It is incremental progress on a deal linking Israeli withdrawal to verified disarmament—but Hezbollah continues to reject giving up its arms absent a full Israeli pullout, leaving implementation fragile.
- **Korean Peninsula:** Pyongyang's 6 August short-range ballistic missile launch from Wonsan, paired with Kim Yo Jong's threat of "additional military options" over Japan's Tomahawk test, signals intent to raise tensions ahead of upcoming US-South Korea exercises. We assess further tests are likely as the drills approach.

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